

THE AGE

MELBOURNE LIVING

edited by STEPHEN DOWNES and PETER WEINIGER (Epicure)

WITH the roses at Flemington the cynosure of all eyes today, what better time to look at the life and achievements of Australia's most noted rose-breeder, Alister Clark.

Working mainly in the 1920s and 1930s, Clark bred more than 100 roses that are truly Australian in terms of behavior and nomenclature.

They were bred for our hot, dry climate, being hardy, fragrant, and long and free flowering. Their names he often borrowed from his friends; sometimes these friends were asked if they would care to have a seedling named after them, or they were taken for a stroll around the

garden to pick out a new rose that appealed to them. Hence 'Lorraine Lee', 'Nancy Hayward', 'Lady Huntingfield' and a host of others most of which are now long forgotten.

For several decades Alister Clark roses have been out of fashion. Perhaps this has something to do with their creator; he produced roses for gardens rather than for the more prestigious exhibition hall.

And rather than sell them, he gave them away, particularly to rose societies and horticultural groups around Australia and even across the world. This generosity scattered them, so that while Clark roses still

thrive in some private gardens his name is not featured in today's catalogues and there is no general collection of his roses to be seen.

But the efforts of 'Age' gardening writers T. R. Garnett and Susan Irvine will redress this imbalance. Tom Garnett is writing Clark's biography, while Susan Irvine is tracking down the Clark roses and planting them in a special garden in her nursery near Malmesbury. Together their researches tell a fascinating story.

Anne Latreille

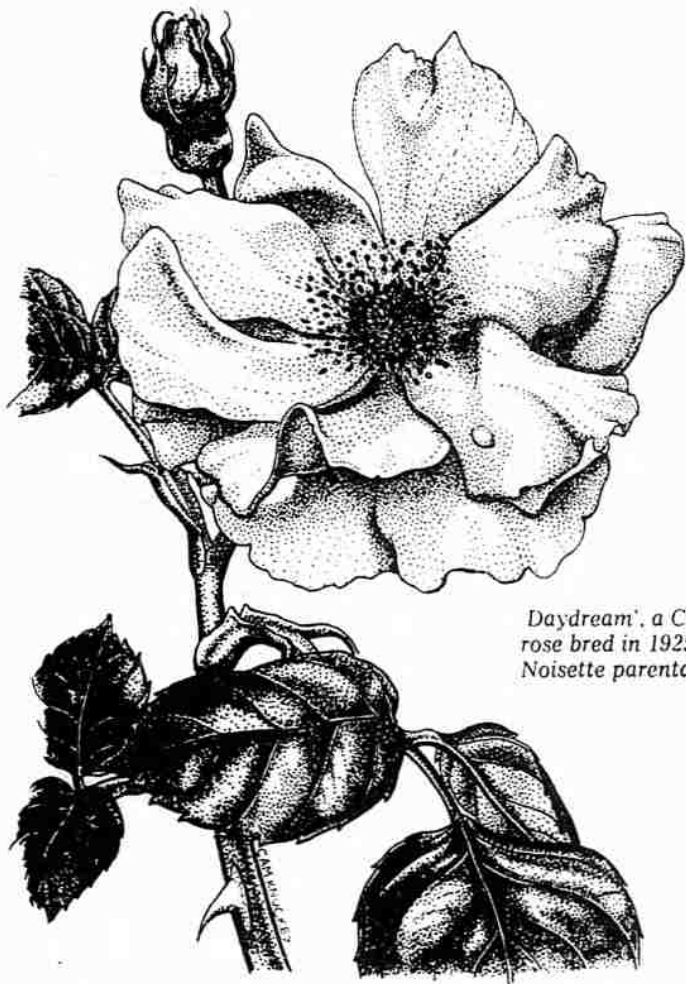
MAN OF ROSES

FOR 44 years Mr H. Byron Moore was secretary of the Victoria Racing Club and used to tell the story of one particularly late season when the roses that are one of the glories of Flemington Racecourse on Cup Day failed to flower. Alister Clark brought containers of blooms from his own garden and had them wired in place.

I have never been able to find documentary confirmation of this tale, but the combination of roses and Flemington was one that would have touched his heart. Each November at the National Rose Show in Melbourne whole tables were covered with decorative roses of his breeding — not for exhibition but as his contribution to a festival of flowers.

"You mean the rosarian?" is the common reaction to mention of Alister. But breeding roses was only one of his activities. He was chairman of the Moonee Valley Racing Club from its inception in 1917 until his death in 1947. He was master of the Oaklands Hunt from 1901 to 1908. He played polo for Melbourne and was one of the first members of Royal Melbourne Golf Club.

He was as renowned internation-



Daydream, a Clark rose bred in 1925 of Noisette parentage.

By T. R. GARNETT

ally as a breeder of daffodils as he was of roses. He was a first-class shot with rifle and pistol and a skilful photographer. One thing he seems not to have been particularly good at was driving early motor cars with safety.

His record shows that he was intensely competitive, as younger brothers often are, but this drive was nearly always under tight control. Generally, he was as kindly and equable as a man can be. In 1938, a correspondent wrote to his elder brother Walter: "In recent years I have come to know your brother, Alister, whom I regard as the beau ideal of a gentleman."

Yet there was one occasion in 1905 when Alister was only restrained from suing the Victoria Racing Club by the guidance of his friend, L. K. S. Mackinnon.

Most of his racehorses were steeplechasers and most were unsuccessful though one called Jones won at 7/1 on Caulfield Cup Day in 1903.

Two years later, Alister had in training three steeplechasers, Sultana, Sweeper and Martinique. On 5 July at Flemington, Sultana won easily, only to be disqualified after a protest by the owner of the second placegetter on the ground that no certificates had been lodged. Even a week's golf in the country

could not assuage Alister's rage until Mackinnon's advice calmed him down.

Glenara (pronounced "Glen-aira"), where Alister lived, is a bluestone house built in 1857 by his father, Walter, tucked away beside Deep Creek in Bulla, just beyond Melbourne Airport.

How did the younger son come to be living in the family home and not his elder brother?

Their father's first wife had died in the quarantine station at Sydney Heads soon after their arrival from Scotland in 1838. He was more than 50 when he married again. Nine years later, his second wife, Annie, died while giving birth to Jessie and in 1873 Walter himself was killed in a buggy accident on the steep slopes above Glenara. The five children were entrusted to the guardianship of their cousin, John Kerr Clark, who owned property on the Liverpool Plains of NSW and had married the daughter of the governor of that state.

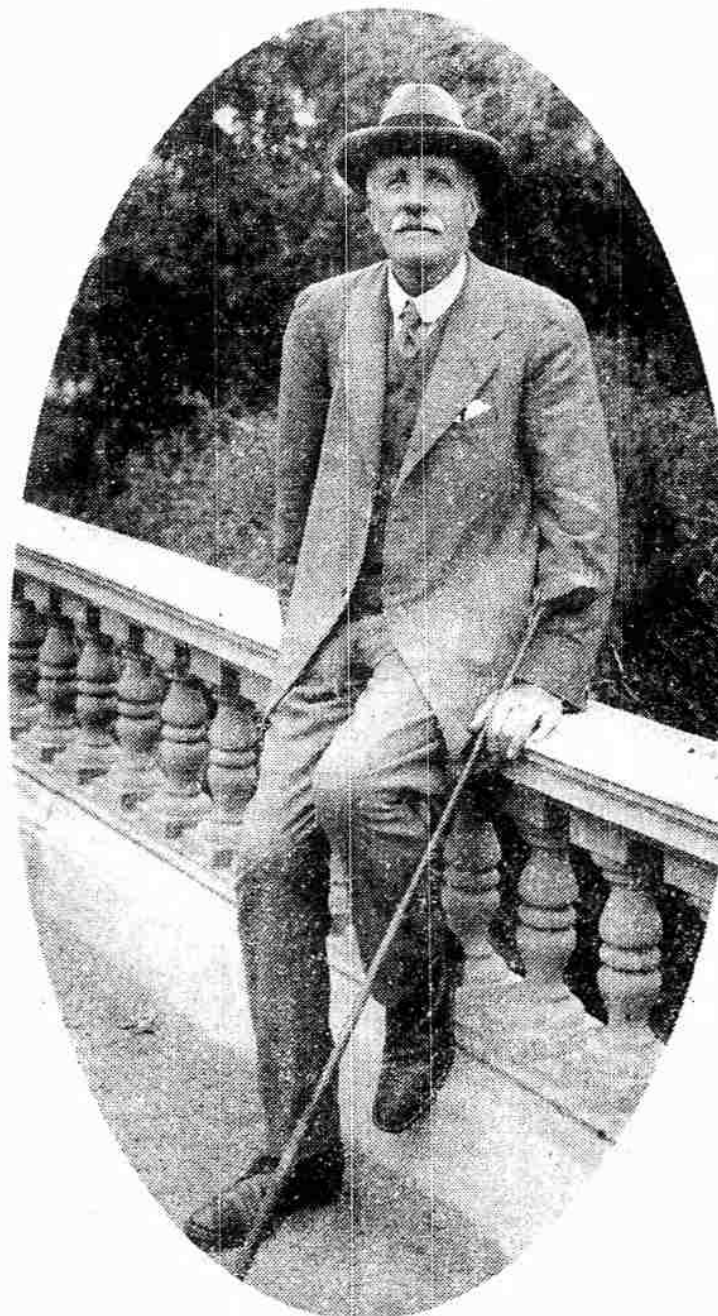
John Kerr laid down that the estate should not be distributed until Jessie came of age in 1887. The children — a closely knit group under the leadership of Walter, who was 13 when the family was orphaned — completed their educations. Alister at the Scottish School, Loretto, and at Cambridge University.

Walter II married Mary Johnston of Craiglee, Sunbury, and prepared to receive his inheritance. He had a passion for heavy horses. He paid large sums for Clydesdale stallions and mares from which to build the stud he envisaged and, in anticipation of the money soon to come to him, ran up a big overdraft.

The Glenara Clarks had become very fond of their guardian and his family, so it was particularly painful when they learnt that he had been sending much of the trust money back to Scotland to sustain his own family home, Crossbasket, south-east of Glasgow. It was typical of the Clarks that his skeleton remained in its cupboard for nearly 100 years. But that cupboard was nearly bare.

Young Walter, therefore, was in no position to purchase Glenara from his father's estate when it was subdivided and put it up for auction in 1887. It was left to Alister, whose share of the inheritance had been managed more prudently during his minority, to buy the homestead and 800 acres.

Alister was lucky. It was the time of the land boom and there were plans (never fulfilled) to build a railway through part of the Glenara estate on its way to Sunbury. Six hundred acres of the 800 he had bought for about eleven pounds an acre in 1887 he was able to sell in the following year for 60 pounds an acre. Over the years, he bought back most of this land (for



Alister Clark at Glenara.

all his geniality "he was a very shrewd old man", as one of his friends recalled).

At the time of this second sale, Alister and his new bride, Edie, were in Britain where his love of gardening, sown as he watched the garden at Glenara grow under the joint care of his parents, was nourished by the acquaintance of what we might now call "the horticultural establishment" of Britain. From them and on their advice, he obtained the daffodil bulbs and rose-bushes which became the foundation stock of his plant-breeding program.

It was not until 1891 that he first lived at Glenara, but there he remained until his death 56 years later. Like most people with varied interests, he was conservative in his allocation of time. Almost

every Saturday he spent at the races. Indeed, reading his somewhat laconic diaries, it is sometimes a little difficult to be sure whether the lists represent roses or polo ponies, daffodils or winners at Williamstown or Flemington.

At Moonee Valley, the Craiglee Stakes still recalls his friends, the Johnstons of Craiglee, Sunbury, and the Alister Clark Stakes (never, one hopes, to be sponsored) recalls the man himself.

The owner, trainer and jockey of that race's winner still receive bowls of roses with their trophies. Perhaps one day, there will be a late winter steeplechase at Flemington for which the trophies will be adorned with daffodils. It might compensate for Sultana's disqualification 80 years ago.

Hunting for Alister Clark's long lost blooms

By SUSAN IRVINE

IT WAS an article in 'The Age' by T. R. Garnett published some two years ago that first made me aware of Alister Clark.

I was acquainted with two of his roses — the well-known 'Lorraine Lee', of which a huge climber cascaded over the fence of my weekend cottage at Castlemaine, filling the whole of the small back garden with its heady scent, and 'Blackboy', with its velvety red blooms, which grew along the back fence. But other than these I knew nothing of Australia's greatest rose breeder.

A week or so after reading Tom Garnett's piece, I acquired by chance a copy of Rossi's 'Modern Roses in Australasia' (1930). Rossi was the authority on roses of his time. He spoke in glowing terms of Alister Clark, and his book contained no fewer than four photographs of 'Sunny South', which he described as "the most useful decorator rose yet raised anywhere". So impressed was Rossi that he had called his own nursery Sunny South. There were photographs, too, of 'Gwen Nash', which Clark himself described as "the most beautiful thing in decorative pinks I can hope to produce".

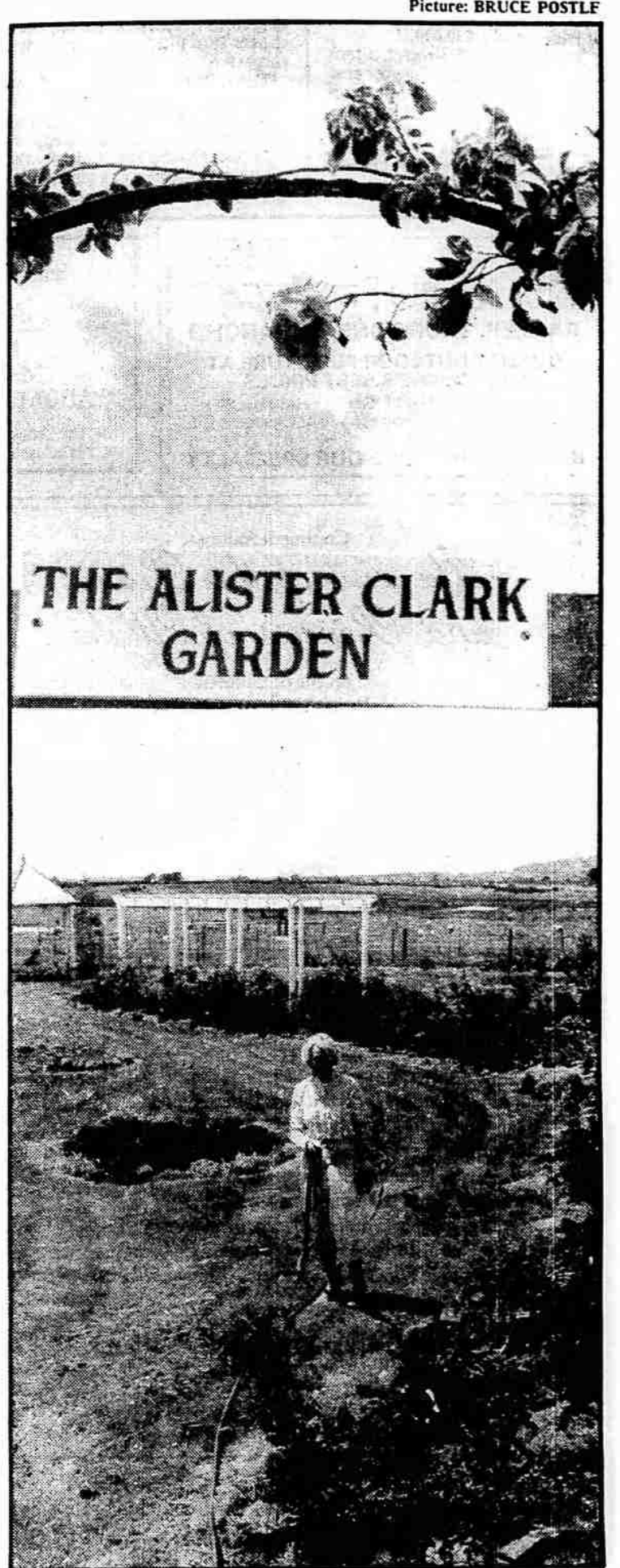
I began to wonder where these roses might be obtained and looked in vain through my rose catalogues. The only ones listed were 'Lorraine Lee', 'Blackboy' and, sometimes, 'Nancy Hayward'. Clearly they were not to be found through the normal channels.

Then I found a catalogue of roses grown in the famous Sangerhausen rose garden in West Germany. This included 11 roses bred by Alister Clark — more than could be seen in any garden in Australia.

I had heard of the Alister Clark Memorial Garden in St Kilda which I visited, full of hope that I might find some of the roses blooming. The garden was in a sad state of neglect — there were only half a dozen Clark roses there, overgrown, weed-infested and some of them dead. No hope of learning anything of Alister Clark there! (The gardens have since been replanted and re-planted.)

So I decided to plant my own Alister Clark garden and to propagate my own plants.

Half an acre of sheep paddock



Susan Irvine: resurrecting Clark's roses.

was fenced in and work began. Many of Clark's roses are climbers, so pergolas had to be erected and a little summer house built at the end of the path leading under them. Silver birches and lilacs were planted behind this, to screen it from the sheep paddocks. Actually, since many of Alister Clark's climbers ('Jessie Clark', 'Doris

Downes', 'Kitty Kininmonth') have in their parentage *Rosa gigantea* — the huge white single rose from Burma and southern China, which grows to 10 metres — I doubt whether any pergola will hold them for long.

A list of Clark roses was compiled from old rose annuals —

Continued Living 5

MEMBERS of the Victorian Socialist Left are a curious lot. They will not go to parties for Charles and Diana. They think Norm is a wonderful guy. They think the prices and incomes accord is the ruin of the working man. They are convinced the 35-hour week is the road to economic glory. They think, too, that the national ID card is utterly villainous.

They have lost me on the first four, but, by heavens I think they might be right on the fifth. Already in my wallet I have three straight-out credit cards, two so-called credit cards from department stores, a bank automatic teller card, a driving licence card and one of those damn security keys.

This is considered extremely conservative for 20th Century agony. There is prestige to be had in credit cards. I know some people who have 25 cards. Their wallets are specially constructed so that they can dangle their credit power in a long streamer.

But let's talk about the security key. This is the real marvel of our time. Most city office buildings now have super security. You get a little plastic disc or card, which by slipping it into a slot in the door lets you inside.

Everyone has his or her own personally programmed key. In

How plastic chips rule our lives

many offices your keys will let you into only certain parts of the building. You are trusted just so far. You may, for example, get into floor two and three, but it will not work for the executive floor, which is the fourth, or for the executive dining room, which is on the starlight roof on the 26th.

I left one organisation, went back the next day with my key, put it in the slot, and lo, it didn't work. I had been deprogrammed. You see, they can turn off your individual key at the touch of a button. Some say these keys are so marvellous that boss man in his office can trace your movements during the day. He can check. "Mmmm, Smithers has been to the lavatory 16 times. Check him out. That's too often."

Well, wouldn't it be a logical extension to make your ID card like a security key? Or couldn't they insert in it some sort of micro chip? This would mean that not only would they be able to check on the number of times Smithers went to the lavatory, but they could also use electronic wizardry to find out the location of Mr. Mrs or Ms Smithers anywhere in the damn country.



DUNSTAN

In the US you get an ID. Instead of being Mr. Mrs or Ms Smithers you are 095 763 3094. This is handy when you are applying for a credit card, terrific when you are cashing a cheque, but unhelpful when you make a dollar because everybody insists on that number for the taxman.

But do you know what worries me? It's another damn number to remember, and I can't remember numbers. Can't even remember my own telephone number, and these electronic creatures are

crowding in on us. We have a word processor computer. It's got its own security. It will not admit your presence or existence on earth unless you remember the magic password.

Our bank has a thing called a Flexicard. It has a number, which it gives you first on a secret piece of paper. The warning is to tear that number into your brain forever, then destroy the piece of paper. How can you do that when you have a brain like mine, which hasn't a proper memory process?

We have a burglar alarm system. You have to get into the house, then you have 30 seconds to turn it off. If you don't make it within 30 seconds the last trumpet goes off, sirens, lights, the works, and security people come running. OK. Say you forget to turn it off, how do you tell the security people not to come? Oh God, you have another secret number, which is supposed to be brain-seared. You telephone the security people, give them that number and then they know peace reigns at your house.

Have you been to a motor show lately? The latest Germanic wonders go for \$100,000 plus. They do not have keys any more. That's old

stuff. They have either security cards or combination numbers. You key in your secret number and magically the door opens. Key in another number when you get inside and that turns off the first number.

Can't you see what would happen? "Darling, help! My parking meter has expired. I've got two tickets and I can't get into the car."

"Oh hell. You've locked your keys in the car again. That's the third time."

"No sweetheart. I can't remember my entry number. They gave it to me on a piece of paper and I did what they told me to do. I swallowed it."

Imagine the ultimate catastrophe. Smithers on his 16th visit to the lavatory, drops his or her wallet or handbag. All the credit cards are gone. He or she is so stunned by this ultimate disaster he or she forgets all numbers, Flexicard number, ID number, number to get into the Mercedes, number to turn off the burglar alarm. He or she cannot even get back from the lavatory into the main office, because the security key was in the wallet or handbag.

That's life in the coming 1990s. He or she might just as well drown him or herself in the dunny.

— Keith Dunstan

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Polly Woodside — 3
100 years young

Softness amid
brick and tar

4

Going Chinese on
the Yarra

7

Brian Croser: hi-tech
wine maker

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